

Dear Editors:

We would like to submit the enclosed manuscript entitled **“Digital Transformation Leadership in Enterprise Systems: Multivariate Modeling and Cluster Typologies of Youth Employment and Retention Dynamics”**, which we wish to be considered for publication in *Systems* for the Special Issue **“Navigating Digital Transformation: Leadership and Decision Making in Today’s Systems.”**

No conflict of interest exists in the submission of this manuscript, and the manuscript is approved by all authors for publication. I would like to declare on behalf of my co-authors that the work described was original research that has not been published previously and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere, in whole or in part. All authors listed have approved the manuscript that is enclosed.

This study investigates how digital transformation leadership and decision-making practices relate to the youth-employment profile of enterprises. Drawing on a survey of 308 firms in Zhejiang Province, China, we measure four practice dimensions—digital transformation leadership, data-driven decision-making, the breadth of artificial intelligence application, and digital skills training—and link them to the share of employees aged 16–29 and the voluntary turnover rate among young employees. Combining MANOVA-type multivariate modeling, exploratory factor analysis, and hierarchical plus k-means clustering, the study provides a systemic, organization-level account of how leadership and decision making shape the position of young people in digitally transforming enterprises.

The innovations of this paper are as follows.

(1) This study shifts the analysis of the digital transformation–youth employment nexus from countries and industries to the organization, where hiring and retention decisions are actually made. It connects the digital leadership and data-driven decision-making literatures with demand-side youth-employment research, treating the age structure and stability of the workforce as strategic outcomes of leadership and decision-making practice.

(2) This study distinguishes technology deployment from the leadership, decision, and training practices in which it is embedded, and shows that their youth-employment associations differ. Digital transformation leadership and data-driven decision-making are associated with both a younger workforce and lower youth turnover, whereas the breadth of AI application is associated with retention but not with a higher youth share. A single latent factor of digital leadership–decision capability underlies the four practices and is significantly associated with both outcomes.

(3) This study identifies two socio-technical configurations of enterprises within a single regional economy. Digitally led, youth-integrating firms and conventionally managed firms with weaker youth outcomes cut across sector boundaries, demonstrating that the youth-employment relevance of digital transformation attaches to organizational capability configurations rather than to technology diffusion alone.

We believe that this manuscript fits well within the scope of *Systems* and the Special Issue “Navigating Digital Transformation: Leadership and Decision Making in Today’s Systems”, as it examines precisely the intersection the Special Issue highlights: how leadership and decision making drive digital initiatives, and how digital transformation reshapes organizational structures and practices—here, the structure of the workforce itself. The findings contribute to a systems-level understanding of digital transformation and offer practical implications for executives and policymakers seeking technology-enabled, youth-inclusive organizational development.

We sincerely appreciate your consideration of our manuscript and look forward to receiving comments from the reviewers.

We deeply appreciate your consideration of our manuscript and look forward to receiving comments from the reviewers. Correspondence should be directed to Xinyu Cai at the following address:

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Thanks very much for your attention to our paper.

Very sincerely yours,

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